The Knife A Story

A Story.

by Sholom Aleichem

SHOLOM ALEICHEM, THE GREATEST OF YIDDISH WRITERS, was born in Pereyaslav, Russia, in 1859, and died in 1916 in New York. "The Knife," one of his earlier works, and originally one of a group of stories for children, is here translated from the Yiddish by Eliezer Greenberg and Isaac Rosenfeld.

Thou shalt not steal!

Listen to me, Jewish children, and I'll tell you a story about a little knife; not a make-believe story, but a true one—it actually happened to me. There was nothing in the world I wanted so much as a knife of my own, nothing in the whole world.

The knife lies in my pocket; whenever I please I take it out and cut what I want with it—and let my friends know that I have a knife!

When I began to go to *cheder*, to Yossel Melamed, I did have a knife, that is, almost a knife. I made it myself. I tore a goose feather out of a feather duster, flattened the quill, chopped off the other end, and pretended that it was a knife and that it could cut. . . .

“What kind of feather is that, a plague! What’s this dragging around feathers?” cries my father, a sickly man with a yellow, dried-out face, and begins to cough. “All of a sudden feathers he plays with—khe-he-he!”

“What do you care if the child is enjoying himself?” replies my mother, a tiny woman with a silk kerchief on her head. “So long as you eat your heart out? Oh, my enemies! Foo!”

Later, when I had begun to learn Torah and arithmetic, I had what was almost a *red* knife, also my own handiwork. I got hold of a piece of steel from my mother’s “crinoline” and set it very cleverly in a chunk of wood. I sharpened the steel on the edge of a pot and as usual cut all my fingers.

“Look, now, look how he got himself all bloody, that son of yours!” cries my father and takes me by the hand so that my bones crack. “A fine lad this is—khe-he-he!”

“Thunder strike me!” says mother. She takes away the knife and throws it into the oven, ignoring my outcries. “Now it’s finished. No more. Woe is me!”

But I soon had another little knife, now really and truly a knife; a wooden hilt, paunchy and round as a barrel, with a crooked blade that sprang open and shut. Would you like to know how I got it? I saved up my allowance for food and bought it from Shloymele for seven cents cash, owing him three. And did I love that little knife, did I love it! I would come home from *cheder* half-dead, hungry, and sleepy and beaten up. (I had just then, you understand, begun to study Gemara with “Moti-the-Angel-of-Death,” the Gemara teacher: “An ox that kicked a cow”—and as an ox kicks a cow, so I deserved a beating.) The first thing I do is take the little knife out of its hiding-place under the black cupboard (there it lay the whole day, as I didn’t dare take it to *cheder*, and at home, you can see for yourself,

no one must know about it). Then I pet it and stroke it, cut through a piece of paper, chop a straw in half, and only then do I begin to cut my share of bread into smaller and smaller pieces, spear them with the point of the blade and finally put them into my mouth.

Later, before going to sleep, I cleaned, scoured, and polished the knife and took up the whetstone that I had found in the attic, spat on it and went quietly to work, sharpening the blade, sharpening and sharpening. . . .

My father, wearing a skull cap, sits over the Scriptures, studying and coughing, coughing and studying. Mother is in the kitchen, busying herself with the *chala*. I keep on sharpening, sharpening the little knife. . . .

Suddenly my father starts up, as from sleep. "What's that twittering? Who's working there? What are you doing, you *shaigetz*, you?" He comes up to me, bends over the whetstone, grabs me by the ear and breaks out coughing.

"Ha? Knives? Khe-he-he!" cries my father and he takes away knife and stone. "A grown boy, would it hurt him to study Scripture? Khe-he-he. . . ."

I begin to cry out, my father improves me with a few slaps, and my mother, her sleeves rolled up, rushes in from the kitchen in great alarm.

"Sha, quiet! What's going on here? Why are you hitting him? God be with you! What are you doing to the poor child? Woe is me!"

"Knives? . . ." cries my father, coughing. "A little child you call that? . . . A hulk of a boy!. . . Khe-he-he. . . . It would hurt him to learn Scripture? A boy eight years old!. . . I'll give you knives, you empty head, you. . . . In the middle of everything, knives yet! Khe-he-he! . .

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Mercy, what has he got against my little knife? What sin has it committed in his eyes? Why is he so angry?

I remember my father as nearly always sick, always pale, green in the face, and always angry, angry at the whole world. He flares up over the least trifle and is ready to run me through. Fortunately, my mother protects me, she delivers me out of his hands.

But my little knife was thrown away, thrown away so far that for eight days on end I looked for it and looked for it, but it was nowhere to be found! I sincerely bemoaned that crooked little knife, that dear, good knife. And how black and bitter I would feel in *cheder* when I reminded myself that I would come home with swollen cheeks, with my ears red and torn from “Moti-the-Angel-of-Death’s” hands, because an ox kicked a cow—and have no one to turn to, no one to comfort me. Without my crooked little knife I remained alone, abandoned like an orphan, and no one saw my tears, which I quietly let flow in bed at night. Silently, I cried myself out, wiped my eyes and fell asleep, and in the morning again to *cheder*, again *an ox that kicked a cow*, again “Moti-the-Death-Angel’s” blows, again my father’s temper, his cough, his curses—not one free moment, not one kind expression, not a smile, not one little smile from anyone.

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A year passed, perhaps a year and a half. I had almost begun to forget about my crooked little knife. But it would seem that I was destined from above to suffer all my childhood on account of knives. A new knife was created, to my misfortune, brand new, a dandy, a treasure, I should live so, an extraordinary little knife with two steel blades, sharp as razors, with a white bone handle, a brass hilt with red brass rivets—I tell you, a real beauty of a pocket knife.

And how do I come by this wonderful knife, which is hardly for the likes of me? It's a long story, a sad but beautiful story. Listen to it, but carefully now.

You can imagine what I thought of the shaved-face, the Jewish German who roomed with us, the contractor, Herr Herz Herzenherz. For although he spoke Yiddish, he went around without a hat, without beard and earlocks and, if you'll pardon me, with his long coat cut short less than half way down his back. I ask you, how could I control myself and not burst with laughter when this Jewish *goy* or *goyish* Jew would speak to me, to be sure, in Yiddish, but what a funny Yiddish, full of "ah's."

"Well, my dear *Knabe*, what's the text for this week?"

"Ha-ha-ha!" I began to laugh and hid my face in my hands.

"*Sage, sage, mein liebes Kindchen*, what is the text this week?"

"Ha-ha-ha! Balak! . . ." I burst out laughing and ran away.

But all this was in the beginning, before I got to know him. Later, when I became well acquainted with this German Herr Herz Herzenherz (he roomed with us a whole year), I loved him so much I no longer cared that he never prayed and that he would eat without first washing his hands. In the beginning I could not understand how he remained alive. How does God tolerate him? How come he doesn't choke to death over his food? What keeps the hair from falling out of his bare head? I had heard Rabbi "Moti-the-Angel-of-Death" say—I heard it from his own mouth—that this Jewish German was nothing less than a *gilgul*. that is, a Jew transformed into a German, who later may yet take on the form of a wolf, a cow, a horse, or even a duck. . . . A duck?

Ha-ha! A fine story! So I would think to myself and I would really

feel pity for this German. One thing I could not understand: why my father, who was a God-fearing, pious Jew, always treated him with extreme politeness, and all the other Jews who came into our house showed respect for him. “Peace be with you, Reb Herz Herzenherz; blessed be the guest, Reb Herz Herzenherz; please be seated, Reb Herz Herzenherz!”

Once I even questioned my father. He pushed me away, saying, “Go on, none of your business. What are you getting under my feet for, what plague is this? Would it hurt you to learn Scripture? Khe-he-he!”

Again Scripture? God Almighty! . . . I *too* want to see what’s going on, I *too* want to hear what he says.

I steal into the hall and hide in a corner and listen in on them, how they are talking in our house, and how Herr Herz Herzenherz laughs out loud while he smokes his thick black “ciga-a-rs” that revive you with their fragrance. . . . Suddenly, my father appears and lets me have a slap.

“Again you’re here? You idler! What will become of you, you *goy*, you? Mercy on me, what will become of you, khe-he-hehe! . . .”

Herr Herz Herzenherz stands up for me. “Let him be. *Bitte*, let him be!”

But it doesn’t help. My father drives me out. I take up the Scriptures, but it’s no go. Who wants to read? What’s to be done? . . . I go from one room to the other until I come to the best room of all, where Herr Herz Herzenherz sleeps. Ah, how bright and airy it is! The lamps are burning, the mirrors sparkling; on the table stands a great silver inkwell with a number of fine pens; little dolls, horses, people, stones, bones, and . . . a little knife. Ah, what a beautiful pocket knife! Imagine, if I only had such a knife! How happy I would be!

What I couldn't carve with it! Well, let's try it—is it sharp? . . . Sharp? It splits a hair! It cuts a hair in two! Oh-oh-oh, what a knife! . . .

In a twinkling the little knife is in my hand. I look about me on all sides and try to put it, just for a second, into my pocket. . . .My hand trembles. . . . My heart beats so loudly I can hear it go tick-tick-tick. . . . I hear someone coming, someone's boots creaking. It is he, Herr Herz Herzenherz! Aie—what shall I do? Let the knife remain with me, I'll return it later. Meanwhile, we must go, get out of here, run away, escape!. . .

I can't eat any supper. My mother feels my head. My father casts angry looks at me and sends me off to sleep. . . . Sleep? As if I could shut an eye. I'm a goner! . . . What shall I do with the knife? How do I put it back? . . .

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"Come here a minute, my precious," my father summons me the next day. "Did you perhaps see the little knife?"

I was terribly frightened. It seemed to me that he knew, that they all knew. I almost blurted out, "Ha? The knife? Here it is. . . ." Something stuck in my throat, and trembling, I answered:

"Where—what knife?"

"Where—what knife?" my father mimics me. "Where—what knife? The golden knife! Our guest's little knife. Overgrown ox, you *shaigetz*—khe-he-he!"

"Why don't you let the child alone?" breaks in my mother. "Is he a fortune-teller that you pester him with knives, knives, knives? What does he know?"

“Knife, knife! What do you mean he doesn’t know?” cries my father in anger. “The whole morning he hears us yelling knife, knife, knife, knife. We turn the house upside down looking for it, and he asks, ‘Where? What knife?’ Go, wash yourself, you empty head, you *goy*, khe-he-he!”

I have you to thank, Lord of the Universe, that they did not search me. But what’s to be done now? I must hide the knife in a safe place. Where? Aha, in the attic! I pull it out of my pocket and stick it into my boot. . . . I eat and don’t know what I’m eating. I begin to choke. . . .

“What’s the big hurry, a plague!” says my father.

“I’m in a hurry to go to *cheder*,” I reply, feeling myself turn red as fire.

“A scholar he’s become, what do you say to our saint?” he growls, glaring at me. Thank God, I got through the meal and said the blessing.

“Well, my saint, why aren’t you going to *cheder*?”

“What are you driving him for?” says my mother. “Let the child sit still a moment.”

I’m already in the attic. . . . Far, far under the rafters lies the little white knife. It lies there and says nothing. . . .

“Why are you climbing into attics?” cries my father. “You bum, you Bar Mitzvah boy, you bath-attendant! Khe-he-he-he!”

“I’m looking for something,” I reply, nearly fainting in fear.

“Something? What do you mean, ‘something’? What kind of thing is

this ‘something’?”

“A . . . B-Bible . . . a . . . an old Gemara.”

“What? A Gemara? In the attic? Oh, you savage, you! Come down already, come down and you’ll get yours! You bath-*goy*, you dog-catcher, you good for nothing, khe-he-he!”

But I no longer mind my father’s curses half so much as I fear what will happen if they find the knife. Who can tell? What if they decide, today of all days, to climb up into the attic to hang wash or tar the seams? I must get it out of there and find a safer place! . . . I go about trembling. Every glance of my father’s eyes tells me that he knows, that he is just on the verge of laying hands on me because of the knife. . . . But I have a place for it, a fine place. Where? Buried in the ground, in a hole by the wall, and covered with straw for a marker. . . . Home from *cheder*, I run right into the yard and slowly take out the knife. I haven’t even time to look at it, when I hear my father’s racket: “Where are you? Why don’t you go say your prayers, you coach-driver’s apprentice, you water-carrier, you! Khe-he-he!”

But no matter how much my father abuses me and chases after me, no matter how much the rabbi beats me and murders me, that’s nothing against the joy I have when I come home from *cheder* to see my dear, my only true friend—my little knife. But this joy—oh, God! —is full of pain, bitter with dread, with great, great foreboding!

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Summer is come. The sun sets, the air turns cooler, the smell of fresh grass, frogs are croaking, and patches of cloud fly by, without rain, fly past the moon, as though they want to swallow her up; the white moon hides and comes out again, she soars and soars but stays in one place. My father sits down on the grass in a smock, half-naked, wearing a white prayer shawl. He holds one hand in his bosom and

with the other he rakes the ground, meanwhile looking up at the starry sky and coughing. His face against the moon is dead, turned silver. He is sitting right on the spot where the knife lies buried, and he has no idea what's going on under him. Imagine, if he only knew! What would he say? What would I catch?

"Aha," I think to myself. "You threw away my crooked little knife, so now I have a somewhat better one, a nicer one. You're sitting on it and you don't know a thing. Oh, father, father. . . ."

"Why are you staring at me like a tomcat?" my father breaks in on me. "Why are you sitting with your hands folded like a public figure? Can't you find anything better to do with your time? Are you too good to say midnight prayers? May you only not bum, my boy, may a plague only not take you, khe-he-he!"

As he says, may you only *not* bum, may a plague *not* take you, it's a sign that he can't be very angry; moreover, it shows that he's in a good mood. And, indeed, how can one not feel relaxed and at peace on such a pleasant summer night when everyone is drawn and driven out of doors, into the air, the soft, excellent fresh air? Everybody is now outside. Father, mother, the younger children who are picking up little stones and playing in the sand. Herr Herz Herzenherz is also wandering about the yard, without a hat, he is smoking a cigar and singing some German song. He looks at me and laughs. . . . He is laughing at me, I suppose, because of the way my father keeps after me. But I laugh back at all of them. Soon they will all go to sleep, and I will sneak out into the yard (I sleep in the front of the house, on the ground, because of the heat), and then I will have my fill of the little knife.

Every one is asleep. Everywhere silence. Slowly I get up on all fours and quiet as a cat steal out into the yard. The night is still, the air fresh, a pleasure to breathe. Slowly I go up to the spot where the little knife lies buried. I dig it up cautiously and examine it by the

light of the moon. It glows, it sparkles, like gold, a jewel. I raise my eyes and see—the moon is looking right down at me, at my knife. What is she staring at? I turn round; she still looks on. I hide the little knife under my shirt—she looks on. She knows what sort of knife this is and where I got it . . . got it? . . . I stole it!

For the first time since the little knife is mine, this dreadful word comes into my mind. Stolen? Then I am a thief! A thief? In the Torah it is written, in the Ten Commandments, in large letters:



Thou Shalt Not Steal!

Thou shalt not steal! And I have stolen! What will they do to me in Hell? Oh, God! They will chop off my hand, the hand that stole. They will beat me with iron rods. They will fry me and broil me on hot frying pans. Forever and ever will I bum. . . . I must return it, I must give back the little knife, I must not have a stolen knife. Tomorrow I put back the knife.

So I say to myself and I place the knife in my bosom—but it bums me, it pains me. No, I must hide it again, bury it in the ground until tomorrow. And the moon looks down on me from above. What is she looking at? The moon sees, she is a witness. . . . I crawl slowly back to the house, to my bed, and lie down to sleep, but I toss from side to side and I can't sleep. . . . At last I fell asleep, at dawn, and I dreamt of the moon, iron rods, knives. . . . I awoke early and said my prayers with heart and soul, swallowed my breakfast, standing on one foot—and march, quick, to *cheder.*

"What's driving you to *cheder*?" shouts my father. "What's the big rush? You'll have time enough for mischief. Better say your prayers right, and don't skip any words. You'll have time yet to run loose, you rascal, you atheist, you pig-eater, you, khe-he-he!"

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“Why so late? Look here a moment.” The rabbi reproaches me and points to my friend, “Berele-the-Redhead,” who is standing in the comer, his head hanging. “Do you see, you trouble-maker? Be it known to you that from now on his name is no more ‘Berel-the-Redhead,’ as he was always known. No! Now he has a better name. Now he is called ‘Berele-the-Thief!’ Ready, children, all together, sing out: ‘Berele the Thi-ef! Berele the Thi-ef!’”

The rabbi draws out the words in a singsong and all the pupils cry after him, like a choir: “Berele the Thi-ef! Berele the Thi-ef!”

A chill runs over my body; I am turned to stone. I can’t understand. . . .

“Why are you so quiet, *shaigetz*?” cries the rabbi, reviving me with a slap. “Why don’t you sing, thick-head? Can’t you hear everyone is singing? You sing, too: ‘Berele the Thi-ef, Berele the Thi-ef!’”

My hands and feet are trembling, my teeth chattering. But I join the chorus: “Berele the Thi-ef, Berele the Thi-ef!”

“Louder, you *shaigetz*!” cries the rabbi, driving me on. “Louder! Louder!”

And I sing with the chorus, all of us shouting, out of tune:

“Berele the Thi-ef! Berele the Thi-ef!”

“Sh-h-h-h-h-sha!” suddenly cries the rabbi, banging his hand on the table. “—Quiet. Now we will pass ‘judgment’ (In a singsong): Well, Berele the Thief, come here, my boy, come here, darling, but quicker, a little quicker, if you please. (Sing-song): Now tell me, little boy, what’s your name?”

“Berel.”

(Sing-song): “Berel what?”

“Berel . . . Berel . . . the . . . thief. . . .”

‘That’s it, my dear, that’s it, little boy, that’s a sweet child. (Sing-song): Now Berele, may you only be well and strong (singsong), please be so kind, my dear Berele, and take off your fine clothes. That’s it! Well now, and a little quicker! If you please, well then, step lively—that’s it, Bereshi my dear!”

Berel stands naked, as his mother had him. Not a drop of blood in him. He doesn’t move a muscle. His eyes are lowered. A dead one.

The rabbi calls up one of the older pupils, all in sing-song:

“Now Big Hershel, will you leave the table? Here, come here to me, step lively, that’s it Now, if you please, tell us the story, from beginning to end, how our Berele became a thief. Listen to him, boys, pay attention!”

Big Hershel begins to tell the story, how Berel got at Reb-Maier-the-Miracle-Maker’s coin box into which his mother, before blessing and lighting the candles of a Friday night, would throw a kopek, and sometimes two; how Berel got at the charity box, which was locked; how Berel, with a straw dipped in tar, drew out all the coins, one at a time, from first to last; how his mother, “Zlotewith-the-Hoarse-Voice,” became suspicious, opened the box and found there a straw dipped in tar; how “Zlote-with-the-Hoarse-Voice” put the case before the rabbi; how Berel, right after the rabbi had beaten him, confessed that for a whole year, a whole round year, he had been stealing kopeks from the charity box, how he bought himself two cakes and a piece of bread-fruit every Sunday, how . . . and so on and so forth.

“Now, children, sentence him! You know how, this is not the first time. Let everyone pass judgment, what is the punishment for a thief who steals kopeks from a charity box. Little Hershel, you be the first, what does such a thief deserve who steals kopeks with a straw from a charity box?”

The rabbi shuts his eyes, leans his head to one side and lays his right ear on Little Hershel. Little Hershel cries out, in a loud voice:

“A thief who steals kopeks from a box . . . deserves to be beaten till the blood flows.”

“Moishel, what does a thief deserve who steals kopeks from a charity box?”

“A thief,” answers Moishel in a whine, “a thief who steals kopeks from a coin-box deserves to be stretched out on the ground, two men sitting on his head and two on his feet, while two men beat him with salted rods.”

“Topele Tutaritu! What does a thief deserve who steals kopeks from a charity box?”

Kopel Kukariku, a boy who can’t pronounce “k” or “th,” wipes his nose and sings out his sentence with a squeak:



A fief, who steals topets from a toin bots,
deserves to have all de boys go up to him and try
t’ree times into his face: Fief! fief! fief!

Everybody laughs. The rabbi presses his thumb against his Adam’s apple, like a cantor, and calls out in the tone of voice in which one calls to a bridegroom:

Come forth, bridegroom, Sholem, the son of
Nahum, and read the Torah! Now tell us,
Shlomenu my dear one, what is your judgment,
what does a thief deserve who steals kopeks from
a coin box?

I want to answer, but my tongue won't obey me. I am trembling as in a fit, I feel myself choking. A cold sweat covers me from top to toe. My ears are ringing. I no longer see the rabbi, no longer the naked "Berel-the-Thief," no longer my friends; I see only knives, knives without end, white, open knives with many blades, and there, on the door, hangs the moon, she looks at me and smiles, she is human. . . . My head spins and the whole room, the table, the tomes, the boys, the moon that hangs on the door and all the knives go round and round. . . . I feel my legs give way under me. In a moment I will faint. But I hold back with all my strength to keep from falling. . . .

In the evening, when I go home, I feel that my face is on fire, my cheeks are burning and there is a buzzing in my ears. Someone is talking to me but I can't make it out. My father is saying something, he is turning angry and wants to slap me. My mother stands up for me, she spreads her apron like a hen, spreading her wings to keep her chicks from harm. . . . I understand nothing, I care to understand nothing. All I want is that night should come quickly and let me put an end to the knife. . . . What shall I do with it? Confess and return it? Then I'll get what Berel got. Put it back? Suppose they see me? But throw it away and be done, get rid of it! But where can I throw it so it shouldn't be found? On the roof? They'll hear it fall. In the garden? They'll find it. Ah! I know, I have an idea: throw it in the well. A fine idea, so help me, in the well, right here in our own yard! . . . I'm satisfied and I don't care to think any more. I take the little knife and run straight to the well and it

seems to me that I'm holding in my hands not a knife but some ugly, crawling thing from which I must free myself at once. Get rid of it! All the same I regret it—such a wonderful little knife! I stand still a moment, thinking, and it's just like I'm holding a living thing in my hand. I feel pity for it: how can I, how can I, it costs me so much effort, a pity for a living thing! . . . I take courage and let it drop from my fingers—splash! . . . A splash, and that's all. No more knife. I stand at the well for awhile, listening—there is no sound. Thank God, rid of it! But my heart pains me: how could I? Such a knife, such a wonderful little knife! . . .

I return to the house and go back to bed and I see that the moon is watching me, and it seems to me that the moon has witnessed everything that I have done, and I hear a voice from afar: "But you are still a thief! Catch him, beat him, he is a thief! A thi-ef!" I lie down to sleep and I dream that I am running, soaring, flying through the air with the little knife, and the moon stares at me and cries: "Catch him, beat him! He is a thief! A thi-ef!"

A long, long sleep. A heavy, troubled dream. Inside me bums a fire. My head buzzes. Everything is red as blood. Burning rods smite my body and I roll in blood. Snakes and serpents writhe about me, their mouths open to swallow me. . . . I hear a blast of a shofar, right in my ear: *Tkieh*!—toot! *Shevorim*—toot, toot! *Trueh*—toot, toot, toot! Some one stands over me, crying aloud in a sing-song, in time with the shofar: "Beat him! Beat him! He is a thi-ef!" And I am crying; "God, take away the moon! Give her back the little knife! What are you doing to poor Berel? He is innocent—it is I who am a thief! A thief! . . ."

That is all I remember.

I open one eye, both eyes. . . . Where am I? What, in bed? What am I

doing here? Who is that sitting on a stool beside the bed? Oh! Is that you, mother? Mother! . . . She can't hear me. Mamma! Mamma! Maaammaaa! . . . What's this? It seems to me I am shouting at the top of my voice. . . . Sh! I listen carefully. Is she crying? She is crying, softly. And I also see my father with his sickly yellow face. He is bending over a prayer book, mumbling and coughing, sighing and groaning. . . . It would seem I'm dead. Dead? . . . Suddenly I feel my eyes open wide; they are flooded with light, my head is light, my whole body, light. In one ear I hear a ringing, in the other, *dzshinnnnn!* I sneeze: ka-choo!

"God bless you! May you live long! A sign! *Mazeltov!* Praised be the Lord!"

"A good sneeze! Praise God!"

"God is great! With God's help, he will be well! Blessed is God and blessed is His Name."

"Quick, call Mintze-the-Shochet's wife. She can turn away the Evil Eye!"

"Better call the doctor, the doctor!"

'The doctor! What for? Nonsense! *He* is a doctor! The Almighty is the greatest doctor. Blessed is His Name!"

"Everybody, away, please. It's terribly hot. For God's sake, go away!"

"Ah-ha? Didn't I tell you to pour hot wax on him? Who was right?"

"Praise God! The Holy Name be praised! Oh God, God, God. Blessed is He and blessed is His Name!"

They crowd around me, they look at me. Everybody comes up and feels my head. They cast spells against the Evil Eye, mumble over me, lick my forehead and spit out. They feed me, they pour hot soup down my throat and cram preserves into my mouth. They all flutter about me, guarding me like the apple of their eye, they feed me soups and ducklings like a baby, and never leave me alone for a moment. My mother sits by my side and tells me the whole story over and over again, how they picked me up from the ground half dead, how I lay two weeks in hell fire and did nothing but croak like a frog and babble something about beatings and knives. . . . They counted me, God forbid, for dead . . . and then, suddenly, I sneezed seven times, virtually brought back to life. . . .

"Now we see what a God we have, blessed is He and blessed is His Name," cries my mother with tears in her eyes. "Now we know that when we call to Him He listens to our sinful prayers and our guilty tears. And what tears we shed, your father and I, till God took pity on us! Sinners that we are, we almost, almost lost you, God forbid, may it be on my head. And over whom? On account of what? On account of some boy, a thief, a certain Berel whom the rabbi beat up in *cheder* until he was all bloody, poor thing. When you came home from *cheder* you were as good as dead, may I suffer in your place. He is a terror, a murderer, may God pay him back. Almighty God! . . . No, my child, if God grant us health and with God's will you will get back on your feet again, we'll send you to another teacher, not such a bully, such a murderer as this 'Angel-of-Death,' may his name be erased from memory!"

This news, you can imagine, is most welcome! I throw my arms around my mother and kiss her: "Dear, dear mama!"

My father slowly comes up to me, lays his pale, cold hand on my forehead and says to me softly, without a trace of anger:

"Oh, did you scare us, you rascal, you. Khe-he-he!"

And the Jewish German or the German Jew, Herr Herz Herzenherz, a cigar in hi? teeth, leans his smooth-shaven chin over my bed, caresses my cheeks, and says in German:

Gut, gut! Gesund, gesund!

A few weeks later, when I was back on my feet, my father said to me:

Well, my boy, now off to *cheder* and get all this nonsense with knives out of your head. It's time you became a man. God willing, three years from now you will be thirteen and Bar Mitzvah, may you live to a hundred and twenty, khe-he-he!

With such sweet words my father sends me off to *cheder*, to the new teacher, Reb Chaim Tomcat. I had never heard my angry father speak so kindly, and at once I forget his harshness and `his curses and his slaps, just as if he had always been kind to me. If I weren't so ashamed, I would throw my arms around him and kiss him. But who ever heard of kissing a father?

My mother gives me a whole apple and two groschen to take along with me, and the German too lets me have a couple of kopeks and a pinch in the cheek and says in his language: "*Hübscher Knabel Gut, gut*!"

I take the Gemara under my arm, kiss the *mezuza*, and run off to *cheder* like someone new born, with a pure heart, a light heart, with a light, clear head, with new thoughts, with fresh, honest, pious thoughts. The sun looks down and greets me with his warm rays. A

breeze steals up to me, under my ear-locks, the birds twitter: “Tif-tif-tif-tif!” I am lifted up and carried along in midair, I want to run, leap, dance—Ah, how good it is to live and be honest, not a liar, not a thief!

I press the Gemara tight against my heart and run to *cheder* in joy, and I swear by the Gemara that I will never, never touch what doesn’t belong to me, never, never steal, never lie, but always be honest, honest, honest . . .

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